

Praise for *Let's Roll*

'Getting a tabletop gaming group up and running at your school or library can seem intimidating, particularly if you're an adult with little to no experience playing games like Dungeons & Dragons. Thankfully, in *Let's Roll*, Maxwell has done all the heavy lifting for you, clearly breaking down each step and even providing evidence and arguments should you need to get decision-makers at your school or library on board. Throughout the book, Maxwell's passion for tabletop gaming and his determination to make it accessible for everyone shine through. He writes with such heart that, by the time you turn the last page, you'll be ready to pick up your sword and jump into the fray!'

Alex Dunne, author of *The Book of Secrets* and halfling rogue

'A heartfelt and accessible guide, essential for beginners looking to easily introduce Dungeons & Dragons or other tabletop role-playing games to their library, community space or group of friends/family.

Let's Roll! is your helping hand to getting started, written through the real-life lens of Maxwell's experience: a librarian bringing joy and confidence to young people through collaborative gameplay and storytelling. This book presents a fantastic opportunity for compassion, personal growth and, of course, a whole lot of fun with friends old and new. If you've ever thought about running a TTRPG, you're in the right place!'

Alex 'Ally' Foulkes, D&D nerd and author of the *Rules for Vampires* series

'This is the book I've been looking for! So many teachers and other helping professionals dream of using TTRPGs with children, but imposter syndrome gets in the way: what if they don't have an encyclopedic knowledge of the rules, or the seemingly limitless creativity of a pro GM? Reading *Let's Roll* is like talking to a close friend who genuinely loves these games and wants you to love them, too. It's compassionate and beginner-friendly, but also takes a deep dive into the specific joys and challenges of running games with kids. I can't wait to start recommending it to others, it's a critical hit!'

Katie Lear, counsellor and founder of Young Dragonslayers

'Setting up a tabletop role-playing game in your library can feel like a daunting task, especially if you are an inexperienced player - the rules can appear overwhelming and the logistics prompt lots of questions. Lucas is the perfect guide to help you create a successful game; his warm and realistic advice takes into account the unique challenges librarians face and guides you from novice player to confident Dungeon Master! His passion for the proven benefits of playing TTRPGS with young people is infectious and inspiring. This book will be of great help to all librarians looking to join him in his quest to make these games accessible to all.'

Alice Leggatt, School Librarian

'Let's Roll is an essential guide for any person wanting to explore the wondrous world of D&D gameplay. Maxwell walks the reader through every aspect of the game of D&D with passion and clarity. He addresses every possible question that could be raised for a budding DM regarding the mechanics of game play, and demonstrates the incredible benefits so many students have experienced as a result of playing D&D. This book has been crafted with love and passion and will convince anyone to give D&D a try for themselves or their students.'

Gráinne O'Brien, founder of Rontu Literary Service and author of *A Limerick Fairytale*

'As a former teacher, an author specialising in kids' events and an avid fan of role-playing games, I cannot recommend this book highly enough. I've seen in person just how empowering RPGs can be for students but setting up and managing a sustainable group can be difficult.

In this, Maxwell's guide excels. It has everything you need: a perfect balance of meticulous detail and accessible, compassionate, student-forward design, all delivered with an enviable warmth and expertise. Every school should have a copy of this book.'

Dave Rudden, author of *Knights of the Borrowed Dark* and *Doctor Who*

Let's Roll

Every purchase of a Facet book helps to fund CILIP's advocacy, awareness and accreditation programmes for information professionals.

Let's Roll

A Guide to Setting up Tabletop Role-Playing Games in your School or Public Library

Lucas Maxwell

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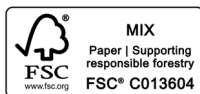
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For Justine.

I could not have done this without you.

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About the Author

Originally from Nova Scotia, Canada, Lucas Maxwell never dreamed he would become a librarian, but is very glad that he did. He fell in love with Dungeons & Dragons when he was nine years old when his brother gave him a battered copy of *Spellfire* by Ed Greenwood. He has been working with teens in public and school libraries for close to 15 years and is currently the librarian at Glenthorne High School in London, England. He writes for the literary website Book Riot and has contributed to the *School Library Journal* and American Library Association publications. In 2017 Lucas was named the School Librarian of the Year by the UK's School Library Association. In 2022 he won the Open University's Reading for Pleasure Teaching Award and the WriteMentor Novel in Development Award for his middle-grade contemporary novel *You Have Selected Power Drive*. His dream is to one day become an author in addition to being a librarian. He is currently the Dungeon Master for some amazing high school students and some equally amazing adults. He lives in Surrey, England, with his wife, two children and one always-hungry chocolate labrador.

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Glossary

Armour Class: The number that dictates how hard it is to hit you. For example, if your warrior has an Armour Class of 15, enemies must roll a 15 or higher on their attack rolls in order to do any damage.

AoE: Area of Effect. This typically refers to magic spells that affect a wide area rather than one specific creature.

Battle mat/map: A board or online board with hexes or squares to determine an area that players traverse. It does not necessarily have to be where battle takes place.

BBEG: Big Bad Evil Guy. This refers to the end boss or central villain in the story.

BTB: By the Book. *See* RAW.

D&D: Dungeons & Dragons

d20: A 20-sided die or dice.

Difficulty Check (DC): A number that a player must meet or exceed in order to achieve a particular goal. For example, a player wants to leap off the edge of a cliff and grab a rope. The DC for this action is 15. If the player rolls a 15 or higher - success! If they roll under 15, well, the GM gets to decide what happens next!

DM: Dungeon Master, also referred to as the Game Master. The person who organises, plans and delivers the game.

Dungeon Crawl: Refers to a specific kind of game where there is less role-playing and more exploring dungeons where a lot of combat takes place.

Experience points: Points that players accumulate in order to level up their characters.

Fudge: When a GM tells the players a different dice roll than what they actually rolled. For example, the GM rolls a 20 on an attack (usually considered a critical hit) but the GM knows that this will kill a player. Instead, the GM tells the player that they rolled a much lower number and survived.

Game Round Table RPG Guild: A Discord group that discusses tabletop role-playing games, offers support and much more.

GM: Game Master, also referred to as the Dungeon Master. The person who organises, plans and delivers the game.

Hex Crawl: A game where players explore large areas of a map, often travelling many miles to get from point A to point B.

Homebrew: A kind of adventure made entirely from the GM's head and not using pre-made adventures, characters or scenarios.

Hook: A prewritten part of a character's back story that ties it in with the overall story of the campaign.

HP: Hit Points. This number dictates your health in the game.

Initiative: How the GM determines the order that players take turns during combat.

Meat Shield: A player that can withstand a lot of damage and purposely blocks others from taking major damage so that they can perform other tasks or duties during combat.

Melee: Hand-to-hand combat, or close-quarters combat.

Milestone: An alternative to *Experience points* where players level up based on the quests they complete rather than being given a set number of points. These milestones can be determined by the GM. Example: 'You saved the villagers from the goblins and you found the child's missing puppy, that's enough to level up, welcome to level two!'

Minifig: A term used to describe a miniature figurine that represents a player, monster or character.

Nerf: To purposely reduce the power of an item or character ability in order to level the playing field.

NPC: Non-Player Character. A character typically greeted by the GM for the players to interact with or learn more from. In some instances, NPCs join the players on quests.

OoC: Out of Character. Players usually use this during online gaming where they step outside of their character's voice and use their own to talk about something non-game related or ask a specific question about the rules.

One Shot: An adventure that can be fully completed in one session.

OP: Over Powered, typically referring to a weapon or ability that other players feel gives a player unfair advantage over other things in the game.

PvP: Player versus Player.

RAW: Rules as Written. Refers to following the rules exactly as they are written in the book.

RP: Roleplay

RPG: Role-Playing Game

Rule of Cool: When a player does something unorthodox and slightly bends the rules but it makes for a memorable experience and the GM allows it.

Rule Zero: The idea that the GM has final say on all rulings despite what the rule book says.

Sandbox: When players appear to have absolute freedom of movement. The GM provides multiple routes, places and quests and allows the players to choose where they want to go and what they want to do.

Session Zero: A session you have with your players before you actually play the game. This is a session aimed at character creation, setting the ground rules and ensuring everyone is on board with what style of game they are going to play.

Tank: A player that is very tough, strong and able to withstand a lot of damage before succumbing.

Theatre of the Mind (ToTM): When you play a tabletop role-playing game and don't use maps or miniature figures, you and your players simply imagine what is happening.

TPK: Total Party Kill

TTRPG: Tabletop Role-playing Game

XP: *see* Experience Points

Introduction

The library tables were pushed together, eight teens crammed around them. In front of them lay character sheets, snacks, dice, notes, illustrations and more snacks.

One player, a wizard, had found a wand and decided to cast it on an enemy they had encountered in a haunted amusement park. 'I use my wand to kill this evil dude!' he yelled. The wand was powerful but the power came with a cost, there was a chance that it would fail and sometimes a random negative effect would take place. This was one of those times.

Instead of sending an arc of blue lightning to kill the enemy, it exploded in the wizard's face in a cloud of pink dust. Almost immediately, all of his character's hair fell out and landed on the ground at his feet. 'I love this game so much!' he shouted in between fits of cry/laughter.

Playing Tabletop Role-playing Games (TTRPGs) in my school library has changed my life. I do not say this lightly. It truly has been a form of therapy for me. Whatever type of TTRPG you decide to play, whatever number of students you can bring in, your goal should be to have a moment like the one described above.

Thank you for purchasing this guide! I really hope you find it useful. Why have I written a book helping librarians to run TTRPGs? One of the main reasons is that they can be a huge amount of fun. In fact, this would be my number one rule: to have fun. If you aren't having fun with your players, you will need to ask yourself or your players why this is. Yes, the games can be chaotic and sometimes feel slightly unhinged, but if you organise yourself and do a little preparation, the sessions will be very beneficial.

The games, activities and events that I will discuss in this book are meant to be a catharsis. I want to share the research and discussions I've had with other people from around the world in regard to the benefits you can take away from playing TTRPGs.

Another reason I wanted to write this book is that I genuinely feel they can act as a form of therapy for both you and the youth you serve. I am not a psychologist, so I'm not qualified to say what the actual impact is, but I know it has helped me a great deal.

That said, I have spoken to medical professionals, other librarians and players themselves about these benefits and I want to ensure that public

and school librarians understand how great TTRPGs can be. Yes, they are games, but there is a tangible mental health and well-being benefit to them. I know this because I benefit greatly from them myself. TTRPGs are a form of therapy. You might think to yourself, 'Well, I'm just playing a game,' but as this book will explore, there is a lot of research to prove how therapeutic this can be.

I also wrote this book because when I first approached TTRPGs I felt a huge amount of anxiety. The scope of the games simply felt too massive: I was overwhelmed by all of the rules and I was paranoid that I was missing something crucial. This stopped me from becoming a GM (Game Master), not only in the school where I work but in my personal life as well. I felt like I wouldn't live up to the GMs I was watching on YouTube.

The truth is, you never have to live up to those people. They are amazing, yes, but they are amazing for different reasons. They are usually professional actors or get to play TTRPGs for a living. I wish I could play games like this for a living, but for 99.9% of us it's a hobby that we get to do in the extremely little free time we have.

Therefore, this book is also here to tell you not to be hard on yourself. If you and the students or teens you work with are having fun, that is all that you need to worry about.

One thing that helped ease my anxiety around running a TTRPG was learning about the 'rule of cool', which essentially means that you as a GM can allow things to happen that bring fun and excitement to the table even if they bend the rules. In this light, I realised that it didn't matter if I forgot the intricacies of every rule. Is everyone having fun and laughing together as a team? If the answer is yes, then I carry on the way I was.

By the same token, I hope this book helps to bring some clarity to public and school librarians, and also teachers, who really want to try a TTRPG in their school but are feeling that same sense of anxiety that I did.

This book will also offer alternatives to the big names in the TTRPG world. For example, many librarians might be considering starting a Dungeons & Dragons (D&D) programme in their public or school library. I currently run D&D and it is a lot of fun, but it does take a lot of time and effort. Therefore, in my opinion, if you are going to run D&D, you have to love it yourself and have some extra time on your hands, otherwise I really feel it will fall apart.

Luckily, for anyone who feels like they don't have the time to pour into creating a D&D environment in their library, there are dozens of alternatives out there. I mention these and describe them in more detail in Chapter 5. The bottom line is that these will save you hours of time, they

are light on rules and are aimed at younger audiences than traditional TTRPGs like D&D.

The other thing I know is that these games are unique to any other programme I've ever run in a library for over 15 years. The reason it's unique? The students *never* miss a session. When I run manga club, book club, film club, mock trial, maker space or any of the other clubs in our library, students come and go, they have other commitments or they lose interest. This is the only programme where this has not happened. The same six students who started playing this game with me in November 2020 are still with me as I write this nearly two years later. It has also gained many more students, and I will explain how I organise the programme in Chapter 1.

This is why TTRPGs are unique and why I hope this guide will be helpful in getting you started.

Who am I?

I am currently the school librarian at Glenthorne High School in Sutton, Surrey, England. I have been in this position since 2013. Before that I was the Teen Services Librarian at Halifax Public Libraries in Nova Scotia, Canada, where I'm originally from.

When I was in the fourth grade our teacher read *The Hobbit* out loud to us, and it changed my life. I couldn't believe a book like that even existed. I immediately asked to be given *The Lord of the Rings*, but didn't actually tackle reading it until much later.

Around this time, my brother introduced me to D&D, specifically the book series surrounding the fantastic character Drizzt Do'Urden and his friends Breunor and Wulfgar. I was hooked. I loved every aspect of it. I got the game Hero Quest for Christmas and wore it out. I got stacks of graph paper from school and made my own dungeons, complete with back stories and filled with demons and monsters.

That said, I actually played a very limited amount of the tabletop version of D&D in the mid- to late 1980s. This was the era of Advanced D&D 2nd edition. Growing up in a very rural area of Canada, I found it hard to find people who wanted to play and there was no internet, so I read the *Forgotten Realms* book series and played D&D games on my Tandy 1000 home computer. These were games like *Champions of Krynn* and *Eye of the Beholder*. These were the things that kept TTRPGs in my mind as I grew up. In my teens I got out of TTRPGs until I discovered computer games like *Everquest*, when I was in my early twenties. Therefore, I never really felt that I stopped being in love with TTRPGs; I just didn't realise

how much of an impact these types of games and novels had on me. Then, when I was in my early forties, I was diagnosed as autistic. This came as both a huge shock to me and not a shock at the same time. I was able to piece things together in my life and I slowly realised that TTRPGs like D&D were my special interest as an autistic person. I just didn't know it before. I can talk about these kinds of games for hours, I can create multiple NPC (Non-Player Characters) with fully fledged backstories, I can regale others with my characters' exploits, to either their amusement or confusion. To make a long story short, TTRPGs have been hugely important in my life and have acted as a form of therapy for me, and continue to do so.

How I started a TTRPG in my library

Pre-COVID, I ran D&D mostly through the massive popularity of the horror sci-fi TV programme *Stranger Things*. I surveyed the students and asked them if they would enjoy starting a TTRPG in the library. The response was overwhelming: the students were very interested in starting one.

I spent roughly £14 (USD17) to get things started. At the time, it was entirely student led. You may find this works best for your space, considering the amount of time you have available. During this time I had two students who knew TTRPGs well and could act as the GM without a lot of guidance from me.

In all honesty, at that time I felt somewhat overwhelmed by the world of TTRPGs and I did not have enough time to invest. My advice is to seek out older, more mature students to lead a TTRPG if you do not have the time to invest in it yourself. In Chapter 4, I provide step-by-step instructions on how to help a teen become a great GM.

Just prior to the COVID lockdown in March 2020, the students who were acting as GM had new commitments that meant they could no longer take part in running the sessions. The need was definitely still there, and so I decided to try to take over and become GM. It's not as hard as it seems. Yes, it can feel overwhelming, but it doesn't have to be. I will provide more tips and hints on this in Chapter 4.

When the country went into lockdown, I assumed that playing TTRPGs was all over for the time being. It turned out that it was only getting started. Our school used Microsoft Teams to run virtual lessons throughout the lockdown, and so I decided to use Teams to run our TTRPG sessions. It was a huge success, and it also meant that we could run it almost every single day either at lunch times or after school, mainly because the students did not have anywhere to go, and neither did I.

It was a lot of fun and hugely therapeutic for me mentally during a stressful time. I feel that it was also the same for the students as they never missed a session. These same students are still playing twice weekly with me and haven't missed a session in a very long time.

When we went into our first lockdown here in the UK, I also started to play D&D with my son. Looking back, it was a way to reduce anxiety that we both had. The first lockdown was very strict and there were a lot of unanswered questions circulating, so it became a way to ease our anxiety, and because I had more time on my hands I started to get excited about it. I bought all the books and dove straight in. I will discuss what you need to play TTRPGs in Chapter 3, and I want to assure you that you do not have to spend a lot of money to play.

We came out of lockdown and I almost immediately had students asking if we could start up again, and this time I felt more confident in running the group so I decided that I would take more control over it and take on permanent GM duties.

I think that if you ask the students or teens in your library, you will find that yes, they are very interested in starting or creating a TTRPG club in your library.

How to use the book

This book is not necessarily meant to be read from beginning to end. Instead, you may find that you are already at a certain stage at setting up a TTRPG programme in your school or public library. This section will give a brief summary of each chapter so that you can determine which one is right for you to get started with.

Chapter 1 focuses both on attracting players to the game and on convincing the powers that be that running a TTRPG is a good idea. This might not be an issue for you. It wasn't for me, but things always change, so it's important to know effective ways to promote the games and to bring in interested students. The chapter also covers proposals for convincing line managers and senior leaderships to be on board with the programme. I also discuss the mental health and well-being benefits of playing TTRPGs in the library. All of these put together make for an amazing package to bring to your senior leadership or management team so they can be made aware of the benefits. Unfortunately, it's easy for many to view these as frivolous uses of a librarian's time, but as drama therapist Katie Lear says, 'every time you play, you are engaging in therapy for these kids'.

Chapter 2 consists of five case studies from librarians around the world, focusing on how they set up their TTRPGs, the benefits they see from them,

any issues that arise and how they pitched their programmes to senior leadership and management. The chapter also provides an example TTRPG proposal for you to use if you need it.

Chapter 3 provides step-by-step instructions on how to start a TTRPG in your school or public library. The chapter covers promotion, ways to keep the game moving and ways that will help you avoid the game becoming mired down. Sometimes when this happens it can cause a lot of disruption and you find that your entire time spent planning the session has been lost to something that could have been cleared up quickly. There are several tricks and tips that can be applied to ensure that your players aren't getting bored or too distracted. There is a fine balance between enforcing rules at the table and making sure everyone is having fun. I think that if you use the right TTRPGs (see Chapter 5), then you will be one step ahead of the game.

Chapter 4 covers what is called Session Zero. This a session (or multiple sessions) that can take place in person or even over a series of e-mails that will help students to understand what kind of game they are getting involved in. This will be especially helpful for them if they are completely new to the game or if you yourself are fairly new to it. In my opinion, holding a Session Zero will help to remove any ambiguity and establish clear rules about the game. This is an important chapter because Session Zero can be as involved or as quick as you want it to be. My advice is to take your time and get to know your players a little bit before launching in, especially if you are running a longer campaign in a TTRPG like Quest or D&D (see Chapter 5 for an in-depth exploration of TTRPGs like Quest).

Chapter 5 comprises four things. First, there is a list and review of 20 great TTRPGs that you can have in your library. All TTRPGs require you to roll dice; sometimes these are multi-sided, sometimes they are standard, six-sided dice. Each review in the chapter contains information on what kind of dice are required. The chapter then provides links to online resources and a further reading list, as well as a list of fiction books for children aged 9+.

I hope you enjoy reading this book, and I hope you will feel confident enough to start your own TTRPG in the library after reading it. Good luck, and let's roll!